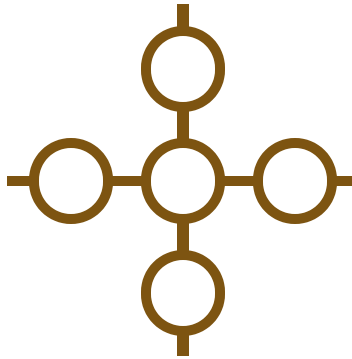


CITIPOINTE CHURCH



Multiply

disciples making disciples

A SMALL GROUP LEADER'S GUIDE

Volume One · Foundations and the Promise

This guide accompanies *Multiply: Disciples Making Disciples* by Francis Chan with Mark Beuving (David C Cook, 2012). It does not replace the book and does not reproduce it. Every member of the group needs to either read the book or use the group member companion guide.

Each session opens with a single page you can hold during the meeting, followed by preparation notes to read earlier in the week. Scripture quotations are from the ESV® Bible, copyright © 2001 by Crossway. Used by permission. All rights reserved.

Contents

Twelve sessions, listed by week

SEASON ONE: FOUNDATIONS AND THE PROMISE

Part I: Living as a Disciple Maker

Week 1	What Is a Disciple?
Week 2	The Command to Make Disciples
Week 3	The Heart of a Disciple Maker

Part II: Living as the Church

Week 4	Life in the Church
Week 5	The Local Church
Week 6	The Global Church

Part III: How to Study the Bible

Week 7	Why Study the Bible?
Week 8	Studying the Bible Prayerfully and Obediently
Week 9	Studying Logically

Part IV: Understanding the Old Testament

Week 10	Creation
Week 11	The Fall
Week 12	God's Covenant with Abraham

Start here

You are not the expert in the room, and the evening does not depend on you being impressive. Chan's whole argument is that disciple making was never meant to be handed to professionals. A leader who performs the professional role quietly contradicts the material while teaching it.

The book carries the teaching. You carry the room. That is a smaller job than it feels like at midnight the night before.

WHAT YOU ARE ALLOWED TO DO

Read this list before your first meeting, and again any week you feel behind.

You are allowed to not know. Say so, write the question down, and bring something next week. A leader who admits a limit is teaching the group how to handle the Bible honestly.

You are allowed to skip questions. Three good questions well discussed beat six rushed ones. The extras exist for nights when the room is still going, not as a quota.

You are allowed to run out of time. Nothing in this material has to be covered. It has to be obeyed, which is a different test.

You are allowed to end early. A group that finishes at nine having said one true thing is in better shape than a group that fills ninety minutes.

You are allowed to be affected by it. You are working through this as a member first and a leader second. If a session convicts you, say so out loud. That will do more for the group than any technique in this guide.

You are allowed to have a bad night. Some evenings fall flat for reasons that have nothing to do with you. Show up again the following week.

HOW EACH SESSION IS LAID OUT

Every session has two tiers.

The night at a glance is the part you hold during the meeting. It is one page: the conversation over food, the passage, three questions, the one thing most likely to go sideways, how to close, and what to pray. If you read nothing else, read that page and you can lead the evening.

Everything after it is preparation, not performance. A bulleted summary of Chan's argument so you can see the shape of the chapter, three spare questions, fuller notes on where people get stuck, and anything worth doing before you meet. Read it earlier in the week. Do not take it into the room.

A RHYTHM FOR THE EVENING, NOT A TIMETABLE

Sessions are built for about two hours including a meal. A shape that works:

Eat together first, unhurried, roughly the first half hour. Ask the food question early so every voice is in the room before anything harder starts.

Pick up last week's follow through, briefly. Ask two or three people by name.

Read the passage aloud without rushing it.

Discuss. This is the bulk of the evening and should have most of the time.

Land it on something specific that somebody has to do before you meet again.

PRAY .

Those are movements, not slots, which is why no session page carries minutes. If the discussion is alive, let it run and shorten what follows. If it has died, move to the application early rather than pretending. Some nights the meal is the ministry and you barely open the book. That is not a failed meeting.

RUNNING THE ROOM

Silence after a question is not failure. Count to ten before rescuing it. The person who needed eight seconds is usually worth hearing.

When somebody says something wrong, ask where they see it in the passage rather than correcting flat. Most of the time they find their own way, and the group learns to check a claim.

Watch the quiet ones. One short question that every person answers, once an evening, beats any technique for drawing people out.

Ask for specifics in the application. “I’ll be more loving” is not a commitment. “I’ll call my brother on Thursday” is.

WHERE THIS IS HEADING

The point of Multiply is not that people finish it. The point is that they turn around and take someone else through it. Say that in week one, and keep saying it. From about Part III, start asking members who they have in mind. By the closing session you are asking for a name and a date.

PACING A LONG STUDY

Twenty four sessions plus a closing meeting is roughly two years at one a week. Groups rarely survive two years without a plan, so decide the shape before you start and tell people what they are agreeing to.

Parts I to III are nine sessions and form a complete study on their own. Many groups run those, break, then take on the Old Testament survey. Part IV is nine sessions and is where energy most often drops, so give it a firm start and end date. Part V is six sessions and finishes strong.

You can also split at the end of Part III, sending members out to lead their own groups through Parts I to III while you continue with IV and V. Doing that is more persuasive than reading about it.

THE VIDEOS

Each session has a companion video of about five minutes at multiplymovement.com. Play it at the start of the discussion if you have the setup. If you do not, nothing breaks. This guide assumes no video.

IF THEY HAVE NOT READ IT

This group runs on the expectation that people read the session, and it goes better when they do. It does not run on the condition that they have. Every evening here can be led from the summary bullets and the passage alone, so a member who arrives having read nothing can still take a real part in the conversation.

Say the expectation once, warmly, at the start of the season, and keep saying that reading is worth it. Then stop policing it. Do not open with a survey of who has read, do not apologise for those who have not, and do not slow the evening to catch anyone up beyond the two minutes of summary. People who feel behind stop coming, and a member in the room unread is worth more than a member at home ashamed.

SEASON

Season One: Foundations and the Promise

BIG IDEA

Following Jesus means becoming like Him in the company of His people, and the story we have joined opens with a good world lost and a promise made.

Twelve weeks. This season does two things at once. The first nine weeks are the practical foundation: what a disciple actually is, what it means to live as the church locally and globally, and how to read the Bible without misusing it. The last three weeks open the Old Testament story, taking the group from creation through the fall to the promise God makes to Abraham.

That is a deliberate place to stop. The season ends with a covenant God binds Himself to while Abraham sleeps, and with every promise still outstanding. People should leave the last night wanting to know how God keeps it.

Parts I to III also work as a complete study on their own. If your group cannot commit to two seasons, run those nine weeks and stop there without apology.

Two things to establish in week one. Everyone reads the session in the book before you meet, and everyone is heading toward leading this for somebody else. Say the second one plainly even though it will sound absurd to some of them. You will keep returning to it, and by week twelve you should know who in the room is close.

Watch the energy around week seven. Part III is the most practical material in the book and the part that most directly equips people to lead, so it tends to lift a group that has started to flag.

PART

Part I: Living as a Disciple Maker

BIG IDEA

A disciple becomes like Jesus and makes more disciples.
There is no third option.

Three sessions. This part sets the terms for everything that follows. Do not rush it, and do not soften it. Chan's argument in these three sessions is that following Jesus costs everything and that every follower is commissioned to make more followers. Groups that skate over Part I tend to treat the rest of the book as information.

What Is a Disciple?

Part I, Session 1. Book pages 15 to 26

BIG IDEA

A disciple is someone who follows Jesus closely enough to end up like Him, and that costs everything.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · Go around the table: how did you first come to be around church or around Jesus? Keep it to two or three minutes each and do not let it turn into testimony night. You are building the floor of trust the harder sessions will stand on.

THEN OPEN WITH · Set expectations, briefly. Read ahead, come honest, everyone will eventually lead. Then ask before anyone opens a book: if a stranger asked you what a Christian is, what would you say? Take three or four answers. Do not evaluate them. Write them somewhere visible. You will come back to them at the end.

READ · Luke 6:40 and Luke 14:25 to 33. Read Luke 14 slowly and all the way through, including the two parables and the closing line about renouncing all that you have. Then sit in it for a moment before anyone speaks.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Luke 6:40 says a fully trained disciple becomes like his teacher. If that is the definition, what should be visibly true of someone who has followed Jesus for ten years?

2. Jesus tells two stories about counting the cost, a builder and a king. Why would He make it harder to follow Him rather than easier? What does that tell you about what He is after?
3. Where in your life is there a gap between what you say you believe and how you actually live? Be specific with yourself. You do not have to say it out loud yet.

WATCH FOR . Someone will hear Luke 14 as works righteousness. Grace saves; Luke 14 describes what real faith looks like. Say both halves.

CLOSE WITH . Ask each person to name one specific thing this week that would look different if Luke 14 were true of them. One thing, this week, concrete enough that they could report on it. Write them down. You will ask next week. Then ask the harder question: is there anyone in your life you would consider walking through this book with? Nobody has to answer. Plant it.

PRAY . Pray in pairs. Ask God for honesty about the gap between what we say and how we live. Close together.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- A disciple is an apprentice, and an apprentice ends up like his teacher (Luke 6:40).
- So a Christian who is not becoming like Christ is a contradiction, not a category.
- Repent means turn. It is an action, not an opinion.
- Salvation is grace through faith; part of repenting is giving up the idea that you contribute anything.
- Lord is a title meaning master and owner, so confessing Him means you do not write your own job description.
- It is not joyless duty: it comes down to love of God and neighbor, and obedience is what love looks like.
- Luke 14 asks you to count the cost before you start.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Compare the answers we gave earlier about what a Christian is with what Jesus says in Luke 14. Where is the gap?
2. Chan argues you cannot be a Christian without becoming like Christ. Is there any way to hold that without ending up in works righteousness? Where does grace sit in this?
3. Jesus summed up the law as love of God and love of neighbor. If love is the test, how would you know if you were failing it?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- Someone will hear Luke 14 as salvation by performance. This is the most important thing you will handle tonight, so handle it carefully. We are saved by grace alone, through faith alone, in Christ alone. Ephesians 2:8 and 9 settles that: not a result of works, so that no one may boast. Luke 14 is not the price of admission. It is the description of what saving faith looks like when it is real. Faith that changes nothing was never faith. Say both halves and do not let the group leave holding only one.
- Someone else will go quiet under conviction. Notice it, do not spotlight it, and follow up during the week.
- A third person will make Luke 14 hypothetical. “Jesus didn’t mean literally hate your family.” Correct, it is a Semitic idiom for comparative loyalty, but do not let that observation defuse the passage. The comparison is still absolute.

BEFORE YOU MEET

Read the session twice. The second time, mark where you personally flinched. You will lead this better from honesty than from mastery.

This is week one, so budget time for the frame: what the group is committing to, how long it runs, that everyone reads ahead, and that the goal is for each of them to lead this material for somebody else. Say that last part plainly now. It will feel absurd to some of them. That is fine.

The Command to Make Disciples

Part I, Session 2. Book pages 27 to 38

BIG IDEA

The Great Commission was given to every believer rather than to professionals, and it rests on Christ's authority rather than on your qualifications.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · Who taught you something that stuck? Not necessarily about faith. A trade, a skill, a way of seeing things. What made their teaching work?

THEN OPEN WITH · Follow up on last week's commitments by name. Ask two or three people directly. This is the moment that establishes whether this group takes obedience seriously, so do it every week from here.

READ · Matthew 28:16 to 20. Read the whole scene, including verse 17 and the detail that some doubted.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Verse 17 says some doubted, and Jesus commissioned them anyway. What does that do to the idea that you have to have it together before God uses you?
2. "Teaching them to observe all that I have commanded." Not teaching them to know. What is the difference, and which one does most church teaching actually aim at?

3. Who is one person in your life who is not far from you and might say yes to walking through this together?

WATCH FOR · “I am not qualified.” Do not reassure. The commission rests on Christ’s authority, which is why qualification is not the question.

CLOSE WITH · Everyone writes down two or three names of people they could invest in. Not a commitment yet, just names on paper. Ask them to pray over the list this week. Carry last week’s Luke 14 commitment forward if it went undone.

PRAY · Pray for the names on the lists. Pray by name where people are willing to say them out loud.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- The disciples expected Jesus to fix the world. Instead He handed them the job and ascended.
- Matthew 28 is read as addressed to pastors and missionaries. It was addressed to them, and to us.
- We have built a culture where paid ministers do ministry and everyone else attends and leaves fed.
- Disciple making is not a program to complete. A disciple is by definition a disciple maker.
- The commission has three parts: go, baptize, teach obedience.
- Baptism was a public declaration of allegiance that marked people for hostility.
- Leaders equip; every member does the ministry (Ephesians 4). The usual excuses have no exception clause.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. The command is bracketed by two statements about Jesus: all authority is His, and He is with us always. Why does the command need those brackets? What happens to disciple making when we forget them?
2. Chan says discipleship is more than a program. What is the difference between a program and a relationship, in practice? Which has your experience of church mostly been?
3. If every believer is commissioned, why do so few Christians make disciples? Name the real reasons, not the polite ones.

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- “I’m not qualified” is the objection of the night. Do not soothe it. The commission does not rest on the discipler’s competence, it rests on Christ’s authority and Christ’s presence. Chan’s line is that you disciple out of what you have, not out of what you lack. Point out that the eleven had followed Jesus for three years and some of them still doubted at the commissioning.
- “That was for the apostles” comes up occasionally. Note that the command includes teaching new disciples to observe all He commanded, and this is one of the things He commanded, so it self replicates by design.
- Someone may confuse making disciples with evangelism only. It includes evangelism and does not stop there. Baptizing and teaching are both in the sentence.

BEFORE YOU MEET

This session will surface the objection “I’m not qualified.” Decide in advance that you will not answer it with reassurance. Answer it with Matthew 28:18. The authority is His, not theirs, which is exactly why qualification is not the question.

The Heart of a Disciple Maker

Part I, Session 3. Book pages 39 to 50

BIG IDEA

God weighs the motive behind the ministry, and teaching without love does damage rather than good.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · Tell us about a time you did the right thing for the wrong reason. Go first, and be real. The group will match your level of honesty and no higher.

THEN OPEN WITH · Follow up on the name lists. Did anyone pray over them? Did anything shift?

READ · James 3:1 to 12, then 1 Corinthians 13:1 to 3. Read them back to back without comment in between. The pairing is the point: teaching is dangerous, and gifting without love is nothing.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. 1 Corinthians 13 says you can have every gift and be nothing without love. What does that mean for someone who is good at explaining the Bible but hard to be around?
2. Chan asks why you want to make disciples. Sit with that. What are the wrong reasons, and which of them do you recognize in yourself?

3. Hebrews 13:7 says to consider the outcome of their way of life and imitate their faith. That assumes leaders whose lives can be watched. What does that require of a leader, practically?

WATCH FOR · Motive examination can tip into paralysis. Nobody's motives are clean, and God finishes what He starts.

CLOSE WITH · Ask each person to name one area where their life does not yet match what they would teach. They can name it to the group or to one other person. Then ask what one step of repentance looks like this week. This is the last session of Part I. Ask the group directly: after three sessions, is anyone ready to start walking somebody through Part I while we continue? Let it sit.

PRAY · Confession and cleansing. Pray 1 John 1:9 over the group.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- Wrong motives do not make ministry neutral. They can make it harmful.
- The Pharisees were constantly ministering and are the villains of the Gospels.
- God looks at the heart, not the outward appearance (1 Samuel 16:7).
- To the reluctant: God wants ministry done from joy, not obligation.
- To the eager: teaching is dangerous. James 3 on the tongue is a warning, not a flourish.
- Every gift and all knowledge amount to nothing without love (1 Corinthians 13).
- Teaching what you do not practice is hypocrisy, and Hebrews 13:7 assumes a life open to examination.
- You do not need to be perfect to start. You do need to have counted the cost.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Why would God judge teachers more strictly? What is actually at stake when someone teaches badly?
2. Jesus said of the Pharisees that they preach but do not practice, and that they do their deeds to be seen. What are the modern forms of that? Where does it show up in church culture you have been part of?
3. 1 Corinthians 8:1 says knowledge puffs up but love builds up. Have you seen that happen? What did it look like?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- Motive examination can tip into paralysis. Someone will conclude they should not disciple anyone until their heart is pure. Head that off directly: nobody's motives are clean, and Philippians 1:6 says God finishes what He starts. The call is to examine motives, not to wait for perfect ones. If mixed motives disqualified people, the church would have no teachers at all.

- The opposite failure also shows up: someone treats the whole session as being about other people, usually about a leader who hurt them. Redirect gently to the first person.
- Watch for the group turning on itself. Honest confession is good, group critique of individuals is not. If it heads that way, name it and move on.

BEFORE YOU MEET

This session is about the heart of the teacher, which means it is about you as much as anyone. James 3:1 says those who teach will be judged with greater strictness. Read that before you lead and let it do its work.

Be ready for the room to go quiet. Motive questions do that. Do not fill the silence.

PART

Part II: Living as the Church

BIG IDEA

You cannot follow Jesus alone, and the congregation God has placed you in is His strategy for reaching the world.

Three sessions moving from the individual disciple outward: life in the church, the local church, the global church. The pressure point in this part is commitment. Chan argues the church is not optional and not a service you attend, and most groups have at least one person who has been burned and is holding it at arm's length.

Life in the Church

Part II, Session 1. Book pages 51 to 64

BIG IDEA

Discipleship happens inside a body whose members carry one another's burdens and aim at the heart rather than at the behavior.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · What is the best experience of community you have ever had, in or out of church? What made it work?

THEN OPEN WITH · Follow up on Part I. Anyone start discipling someone? Anyone repent of something they named last week? Then say plainly what this part is about: the book is going to argue that you cannot be a disciple alone.

READ · Acts 2:42 to 47, then Hebrews 10:24 to 25.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Acts 2 describes a group who devoted themselves to teaching, fellowship, breaking bread, and prayer, and who shared possessions. Which of those four is weakest in your experience of church? Why?
2. Chan pushes for getting beneath the surface. What keeps us at the surface with each other? Name the actual mechanisms, not just "we're busy."

3. What is one gift or capacity you have that the body is not currently getting from you?

WATCH FOR · Church hurt will surface. Let it be said before you answer it.

CLOSE WITH · Each person names one specific act of service or encouragement toward someone in the church this week. Not the group necessarily, the wider church.

PRAY · Pray for your local congregation by name, for its leaders, and for the group's own honesty with one another.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- The West admires people who go it alone. You cannot follow Jesus that way.
- The New Testament is full of one another commands, and it is impossible to one another yourself.
- Of roughly 114 New Testament uses of church, at least ninety mean a specific local gathering.
- People avoid commitment for real reasons: self sufficiency, fear of accountability, church hopping, past hurt.
- Ministry is not intimidating once you see it as serving the people already around you (Galatians 6:1 to 2).
- We treat symptoms. Manage an angry man's triggers and nothing changes, because it comes from the heart (Mark 7).
- Only God changes hearts, through His Spirit, His Word and prayer (Ezekiel 36:26 to 27).
- A body grows only when each part works; an inactive member makes the rest compensate.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Hebrews says to consider how to stir up one another. That is deliberate, planned effort. What would it look like to actually plan how to provoke someone toward love this month?
2. James 5:16 says confess your sins to one another. Why do we almost never do this? What would have to be true of a group for that to be safe?
3. Ephesians 4 says leaders equip the saints for the work of ministry. If that is the design, what has gone wrong when the paid staff do the ministry and everyone else watches?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- Church hurt surfaces here, and it is real. Do not defend the institution and do not rush the person. Let them say it. Then ask the honest question: does the failure of a church mean the church is optional? Chan's answer, and the New Testament's, is no. But arriving there takes time and the person needs to feel heard first, not corrected.
- Confession scares people. Do not push the group into confessing tonight. Talk about what would make it possible. If someone confesses something serious, receive it without drama and follow up privately afterward. If it involves ongoing harm or anything requiring pastoral or legal attention, bring it to a pastor.
- Submission to leaders in Hebrews 13:17 can raise real questions about authority and abuse. Do not wave it away. Biblical submission is not unconditional, leaders are accountable to Scripture, and 1 Peter 5:2 and 3 explicitly forbids domineering. Say that.

BEFORE YOU MEET

This is a long session in the book and covers a lot: submission to leaders, confession, discipline, fellowship, every member ministering. You cannot do all of it well in forty minutes. Pick two threads and go deep rather than touching all six.

The two that usually matter most for a group are getting beneath the surface with each other, and every member doing its part. The guide below leans that way. Adjust for your room.

The Local Church

Part II, Session 2. Book pages 65 to 76

BIG IDEA

The world is meant to recognize Jesus by the visible love and unity of His people, not by the quality of our arguments.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · What do people in Nashville who do not go to church think church is? Be honest, including the uncomfortable parts.

THEN OPEN WITH · Follow up on last week's act of service. Then frame tonight: if the church is a body, what is it for?

READ · John 13:34 to 35, then John 17:20 to 23, then Matthew 5:14 to 16.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Jesus says the world will identify His disciples by their love for one another. Not by doctrine, not by morality, by love. Why that? And is that how we are actually identified?
2. In John 17 Jesus prays for unity so that the world may believe. What is the connection between a united church and a believing world?

3. Chan says your local church matters. If your congregation disappeared tomorrow, would the neighborhood notice? What would be missing?

WATCH FOR · This can slide into criticizing your church. Ask what they intend to do about it.

CLOSE WITH · Pick one thing the group could do together for the neighborhood in the next month. Decide it tonight, assign someone to organize it, and put a date on it. A group that only ever talks is being formed by the talking.

PRAY · Pray for the neighborhood by name: streets, schools, businesses, neighbors people actually know.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- Everything about devotion to one another still stands, and it is not the point.
- An inwardly focused church is unhealthy, dying, and biblically not a church at all.
- We are a lighthouse rather than a bomb shelter: not hiding from trouble but guiding others through it.
- The world identifies disciples by love, not by doctrine or morality (John 13:34 to 35).
- Jesus prayed for unity so the world would believe (John 17). We assume arguments will convince; He said unity would.
- That prayer assumes our life together is visible. Hidden church life proves nothing to anyone.
- 1 Peter 3 assumes we suffer unjustly and respond with such hope that people ask. Mostly nobody asks.
- Israel was a kingdom of priests; the church now carries that calling (1 Peter 2:9).

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Matthew 5 says let your light shine before others so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father. How do you do good visibly without doing it to be seen, which Jesus condemns in Matthew 6?
2. 1 Peter 2:9 calls the church a royal priesthood. What does a priest do, and what does it mean that the whole congregation is one?
3. What is one thing your church does well that the neighborhood can actually see? What is one thing it does not?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- This session can slide into criticizing your church. Some of that is useful and some is corrosive. The test: is the person describing a problem they intend to be part of solving, or performing dissatisfaction? Ask them what they would do about it.
- The opposite problem is defensiveness, usually from people who serve on staff or volunteer heavily. Remind the room that honest assessment is not disloyalty.
- Someone will raise the tension between Matthew 5:16 and Matthew 6:1. It is a good question and worth naming: the difference is the audience of the heart. Matthew 5 says let them see and glorify your Father. Matthew 6 condemns doing it to be seen by them. Same action, different aim.

The Global Church

Part II, Session 3. Book pages 77 to 90

BIG IDEA

God promised from the beginning to bless every family of the earth, and nobody can call on a Savior they have never heard of.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · Where in the world have you been, and what surprised you about the church there if you saw it?

THEN OPEN WITH · Report on the neighborhood plan from last week. Hold the date.

READ · Genesis 12:1 to 3, then Romans 10:12 to 15, then Revelation 7:9 to 10. Read them in that order. It is the whole arc of the Bible's missionary purpose in three passages.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Romans 10 works backward: calling, believing, hearing, preaching, sending. Which link in that chain is your church strongest at? Which is weakest?
2. Revelation 7 shows a multitude from every nation, tribe, people, and language. Not one culture absorbed into another, all of them present. What does that say about God's view of the nations?

3. Is there any reason you should not go? Ask it seriously. Not everyone should, but most people have never actually asked.

WATCH FOR · Guilt is the failure mode. Push toward the specific: go, send, pray, learn.

CLOSE WITH · Each person picks one unreached people group to learn about and pray for this month. Assign a different one to each person and have them report back in a few weeks. Ask whether anyone in the group senses God might be calling them to go. Do not press. Note who hesitates.

PRAY · Pray for the groups people chose, and for laborers to be sent.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- Reaching everyone in your town still would not finish the mission.
- Genesis 3:15 promises a rescuer for the human race, not for one ethnic group.
- Genesis 12 narrows to one family precisely so all families of the earth are blessed.
- Paul was a missionary before he was a theologian, ambitious to preach where Christ was not named.
- Romans 10 gives the chain: calling needs believing, believing needs hearing, hearing needs preaching, preaching needs sending.
- Many groups still have no access to the gospel. The assumption that anyone interested can find it is false.
- Everyone is involved; not everyone goes. Go, send, pray, learn are all real responses.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. God's promise to Abraham was that all the families of the earth would be blessed through him. How does that shape how you read the rest of the Old Testament?
2. Matthew 24:14 ties the gospel reaching all nations to the end coming. What do you do with that? How should it affect urgency?
3. Chan asks about places where Christ has not been named. Do you know where those places are? Should you?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- Guilt is the failure mode here. People finish this session feeling bad about not being missionaries and then do nothing, which is the worst of both. Push toward the specific: go, send, pray for, learn about. All four are real responses. Guilt is not.

- Someone may raise questions about those who have never heard. This is a genuinely open question in the church and one your congregation has not settled. Represent the range honestly: the historic view that hearing the gospel is necessary for salvation, and the minority view of some form of merciful provision for the unevangelized. What Scripture states plainly is that God is just, that Christ is the only way, and that the church is sent. Do not pretend the question is easier than it is, and do not let it become the whole evening. Take it offline if it dominates.

BEFORE YOU MEET

This session works much better with something concrete in the room. Find out who your congregation supports overseas and where. If you can get a missionary on a video call for ten minutes, do it and cut a discussion question.

PART

Part III: How to Study the Bible

BIG IDEA

Scripture is God speaking, so it is read prayerfully, obediently and carefully, or it is misread.

Three sessions on handling Scripture: why, how devotionally and obediently, and how carefully. This is the most practical part of the book and the part that most directly equips people to lead. Slow down here. Somebody who cannot read a passage for themselves cannot disciple anyone.

Why Study the Bible?

Part III, Session 1. Book pages 91 to 108

BIG IDEA

Why you open the Bible determines what it does to you,
and knowledge pursued for its own sake puffs up.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · What is your actual history with the Bible? Not what it should be. Have you read it through? Do you read it now? What has gotten in the way?

THEN OPEN WITH · Report on the people groups. Then set up the part: three weeks on how to read the Bible, because everyone here is going to teach it.

READ · 2 Timothy 3:16 to 17, then 1 Peter 2:1 to 3.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Paul lists four uses: teaching, reproof, correction, training in righteousness. Which of those do you actually let the Bible do to you? Which do you skip?
2. Chan names wrong motives for Bible study: guilt, status, gathering teaching material. Which of those has driven you? Be specific.
3. 1 Corinthians 8:1 says knowledge puffs up. How do you study seriously without becoming that person?

WATCH FOR · Shame about not reading. Be honest about your own patchy history first.

CLOSE WITH · Everyone sets a Bible reading plan for the next month: what, when, where. Specific. Have them say it out loud so it exists. Pair people up to check on each other.

PRAY · Pray for hunger. Pray for the ones who have found the Bible dry to find it alive.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- Disciple making means teaching obedience, so we have to know what Jesus commanded.
- We are not at a disadvantage for having missed Jesus in person. It was written down.
- Three wrong motives: guilt, which breeds legalism and quotas; status; and hunting for teaching material.
- God gave the Bible to teach us about Himself, about ourselves and the world, and to make us godly.
- Also to build relationship with Him, to exalt Jesus, and to prepare us for mission.
- We think we read the Bible. In fact it reads us (Hebrews 4:12).
- Approach it as a student rather than searching for agreement with what you already hold.
- Knowledge puffs up. Bible study has produced some of the most arrogant people alive.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Verse 17 gives the purpose: complete, equipped for every good work. Equipped for what? Notice the aim is not knowledge but readiness to act.
2. 1 Peter says to long for the pure spiritual milk like newborn infants. What does spiritual hunger feel like, and what kills it?
3. If the Bible's purpose includes exalting Jesus and preparing us for mission, how would that change what you look for when you open it?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- Shame is the main obstacle. People who do not read the Bible feel bad about it and get defensive or silent. Reduce that by being honest about your own patchy history. Then get practical: most people fail at Bible reading for logistical reasons, not spiritual ones. Wrong time of day, unrealistic plan, no translation they can read.
- Someone will ask about translations. Our congregation teaches from the ESV, which is what this guide quotes. Point people to a readable modern translation and away from paraphrases as their main Bible. Do not turn it into a translation debate.
- Someone reading for teaching material will realize that is their only mode. That is a good realization and worth sitting with rather than resolving quickly.

BEFORE YOU MEET

This is the longest session in the book so far. Do not try to cover all six of the purposes Chan lists. Pick the two your group most needs.

Ask yourself honestly why you read the Bible. Lead from that.

Studying the Bible Prayerfully and Obediently

Part III, Session 2. Book pages 109 to 122

BIG IDEA

You cannot understand Scripture without the Holy Spirit, and you have not finished reading until you have obeyed.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · Tell about a time you understood something in the Bible that you had read many times before but never seen. What was different that day?

THEN OPEN WITH · Check the reading plans. Who did it? Who did not, and what got in the way? Solve the logistics out loud.

READ · 1 Corinthians 2:9 to 14, then James 1:22 to 25.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. If understanding Scripture depends on the Spirit, what does that look like practically when you sit down to read? What would change about the first two minutes?
2. Chan argues we should read expecting to obey. How would your reading change if you assumed every passage required a response?

3. Have you ever avoided a part of the Bible because you knew what it would ask of you? Which part?

WATCH FOR · Two errors sit either side: pure technique, and pure mysticism. Name both.

CLOSE WITH · Take the passage each person is reading this week and have them write one question: what does this ask me to do? Then have them commit to doing it and report next week.

PRAY · Pray for illumination, specifically. Ask God to open the eyes of people in the room to something in the text they have been unable to see.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- People handle Scripture as rulebook, character gallery, mystical oracle, or academic object. Most of us cycle through all four.
- Read it devotionally, meaning devoted. Psalm 119 is 176 verses of delight in God's word.
- We talk about praying and reading. We rarely pray while reading.
- Enough exegesis, Greek and commentaries will not do it. That mentality leaves no room for the Spirit.
- You cannot understand Scripture without the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 2:14).
- Dependence on revelation is not a result of the fall; Adam needed it before there was any sin.
- Read expecting to obey. Study that never becomes action is misuse.
- Read with faith: the promises are as trustworthy as the God who makes them.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Paul says the natural person cannot understand the things of the Spirit. What does that mean for how you approach a passage? What does it mean for how you talk to a friend who finds the Bible foolish?
2. James says the person who hears without doing is like someone who looks in a mirror and forgets what he looks like. What is it about hearing without doing that produces forgetting?
3. James 1:26 and 27 gives a test of real religion: bridled tongue, care for widows and orphans, unstained by the world. How does that test land on you?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- Two errors sit on either side of this session and you should name both. One is treating Bible study as pure technique, as though the right method extracts the meaning like a machine. The other is treating it as pure mysticism, where whatever comes to mind is the Spirit's voice and study is unnecessary. The Spirit illumines the text He inspired. He does not contradict it. Prayerful dependence and careful work belong together, which is exactly why the next session is about studying logically.
- Someone may confuse the Spirit's illumination with new revelation that overrides Scripture. Distinguish these clearly. We believe God still speaks and still gives gifts of prophecy, and we also hold that anything He says now will never contradict what He has said in Scripture. Scripture is the measure.
- Someone will feel condemned by James. Point them to the gospel: the Spirit gives what He demands, and Romans 8:13 says it is by the Spirit that we put to death the deeds of the body. Obedience is empowered, not self generated.

BEFORE YOU MEET

This session touches the Holy Spirit's role in understanding Scripture. Our congregation is charismatic and continuationist, and you should teach it that way. The Spirit who inspired the Word illumines it now, and He is still speaking, still gifting, still active. Do not let the session imply that His work in interpretation is somehow separate from His work in power.

Studying Logically

Part III, Session 3. Book pages 123 to 138

BIG IDEA

A passage has one meaning and many applications, and context is what stops you inventing both.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · What is a verse you have seen used in a way that felt off? On a coffee mug, in a speech, on social media.

THEN OPEN WITH · Report on last week's obedience question. Then set up tonight: this is the practical skills night, and everyone will be doing the work, not listening to it.

READ · 2 Timothy 2:15, then read your practice passage twice: once alone, then with the surrounding paragraph.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Read the practice verse by itself. What do people usually take it to mean?
2. Now read the paragraph around it. What is the writer actually talking about? What changes?
3. Chan distinguishes interpretation from application. A passage has one meaning and many applications. Why does that order matter? What goes wrong when we reverse it?

WATCH FOR · The risk is making the Bible feel expert only. Keep saying the tools are ordinary.

CLOSE WITH · Each person takes a passage this week and writes three lines: what it says, what it means, what it asks of me. Bring it next time. This is the end of Part III. Ask directly: who is ready to take someone through Parts I to III? You have now given them the content and the tools. Name specific people if you can see it in them.

PRAY · Pray for those considering leading. Lay hands on them if that is your practice.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- Careful work does not guarantee right results, and it is still commanded (2 Timothy 2:15).
- We all misread some passages. If we did not, we would agree on every point of doctrine.
- Context first. Think apple rather than orange: a verse is a bite from a whole, not a detached segment.
- A passage has one meaning and many applications. Reverse that and misinterpretation stops existing.
- Find the plain meaning. Luke 12:33 is the test case we reflexively explain away.
- If the literal sense makes sense, seek no other sense, allowing for metaphor, parable and poetry.
- Historical context matters: Jeremiah 29:11 was written to exiles, not printed for coffee mugs.
- The biggest danger is your own baggage, cultural and personal.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Is the meaning smaller or larger than the popular use? For Philippians 4:13, most groups find it is larger, and harder.
2. What is the difference between taking the Bible literally and taking it woodenly? Think of a psalm, a parable, a proverb, a letter. Do you read them the same way?
3. Take one more passage cold and work it together: read the context, state the plain meaning, then ask what it asks of us.

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- The main risk is that this session makes people feel the Bible is only for experts, which is the opposite of the book's point. Keep saying that the tools are ordinary: read the surrounding paragraph, notice who is being addressed, ask what kind of writing this is. That is most of it.
- Someone will discover a verse they have built something on has been misread. That can sting. Handle it kindly and point out that the true meaning is almost always better than the misuse.
- Genre confusion is worth naming if it comes up. A proverb is a general truth, not a promise. A narrative describes what happened, which is not always what should happen. If the group has energy for it, this is worth ten minutes.
- Someone will ask about the historical context and where to get it. Point them at a study Bible and one accessible commentary. Keep the list to two resources, not ten.

BEFORE YOU MEET

This is the most skill based session in the book. Plan to practice rather than discuss. Pick a short passage in advance and work it together as a group. Practicing one passage badly together teaches more than talking about method well.

Suggested practice passage: Philippians 4:13, or Jeremiah 29:11. Both are routinely quoted without context and both are genuinely encouraging when read properly, so the exercise builds rather than deflates.

PART

Part IV: Understanding the Old Testament

BIG IDEA

The Old Testament is one story of God making a people for Himself and coming to dwell with them, and every thread in it is left unfinished until Jesus.

Nine sessions tracing the storyline from creation to exile. This is the longest part and the one where groups most often lose momentum, so say up front that it is nine weeks and put an end date on the calendar.

The thing to keep repeating: this is not a history lesson. Chan's argument is that you cannot understand Jesus without understanding the story He walked into. Every session should end pointing forward. If your group finishes Part IV knowing more facts and loving Jesus no more, the part has failed.

A practical suggestion. Draw the storyline on a single sheet of paper as you go, adding to it each week, and put it on the wall. By session nine the group can see the whole shape. Groups remember the picture long after they forget the discussions.

Creation

Part IV, Session 1. Book pages 139 to 150

BIG IDEA

God made a good world and made humanity in His own image to reflect His rule over it.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · What is something in the natural world that has stopped you in your tracks?

THEN OPEN WITH · Report on the three line passage exercise from last week. Then set up Part IV: nine weeks, here is the end date, and here is why the Old Testament matters for making disciples.

READ · Genesis 1:26 to 28 and Genesis 2:15.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Before anything else, Genesis 1 tells us about God. What is He like, based only on this chapter?
2. What does it mean to be made in God's image? What is it about humans that is not true of anything else God made?
3. If every human bears God's image, what follows for how you treat the person you find hardest to be around?

WATCH FOR · Origins debates. Have one sentence ready and move on.

CLOSE WITH · Ask each person to identify one person they habitually treat as less than image bearing, and one concrete thing they will do about it this week.

PRAY · Worship. Spend this block praising God for who He is rather than asking Him for anything. That is harder than it sounds and worth doing.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- The Bible tells one true story, and it is unfinished. You have a part in it.
- Genesis never answers our philosophical questions about God. It tells us what He did: He created.
- God is the only character in Genesis 1 and the only eternal one, so nothing compares with Him.
- This world is His because He spoke it into being. Our authority over it is delegated, not owned.
- Image of God: rather than pin it to one faculty, read it as reflecting Him. Jesus does so perfectly (Colossians 1:15).
- Kings set up images of themselves to announce who ruled. Humans standing in creation do the same.
- Genesis 2 is more intimate: God forms, breathes, speaks. Adam needed revelation even before sin.
- Work exists before the fall. The curse made it frustrating; it did not invent it.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. Humanity is given dominion and put in the garden to work it and keep it. Work exists before the fall. What does that do to the idea that work is a curse?
2. Colossians 1:15 calls Jesus the image of the invisible God. How does that connect back to Genesis 1?
3. Psalm 8 marvels that God is mindful of man. When did you last actually feel that?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- Origins debates. Have your one sentence ready and use it. Faithful believers differ on age and mechanism, Scripture's concern here is who created and why, and we are not going to spend our evening there. If someone genuinely needs the conversation, offer to have it separately.
- The image of God can stay abstract. Push it toward the concrete: the person you dismiss, the coworker you find contemptible, the political opponent. That is where the doctrine bites.
- Someone may not see why this matters for discipleship. Answer it directly: you cannot explain the cross to someone who does not know what was broken.

BEFORE YOU MEET

Decide in advance how you will handle the age of the earth if it comes up, and decide that it will not eat the evening. Our congregation holds no official position on the mechanism or timescale of creation. What we hold is that God created, that He created purposefully, and that humanity bears His image. Say that, name that faithful Christians differ on the how, and move the conversation back to the text's actual concerns.

The Fall

Part IV, Session 2. Book pages 151 to 160

BIG IDEA

Sin is a declaration of independence from God, and it broke every relationship humanity had.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · What is something you have broken that could not be fixed?

THEN OPEN WITH · Add to the wall chart: creation, and now the fall. Follow up on last week's commitment.

READ · Genesis 3, the whole chapter. It is not long and it needs to be heard as a story.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. Trace how the serpent works in verses 1 to 5. What is the sequence? Where do you recognize it in your own temptations?
2. The first consequence is hiding. Why is shame the immediate result rather than punishment?
3. Genesis 3:15 is the first promise of a rescuer, spoken in the middle of a curse. What does it tell you about God that judgment and promise arrive in the same breath?

WATCH FOR · People want to defend God's fairness over the tree. Let the question be asked.

CLOSE WITH · Where is the pattern of Genesis 3 running in your life right now? The questioning of God's goodness, the grasping, the hiding. Name it to one other person.

PRAY · Pray in pairs, honestly, about what was named.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- You felt the results of the fall today. Everyone senses the world is not as it should be.
- The serpent points at the one restriction so Eve feels deprived, then promises she will be like God.
- The garden was already full of good things. What he offered was goodness apart from God.
- He is subtle, and he is a creature. Be wary of his lies without fearing his power.
- Sin is always a declaration of autonomy: the right to decide good and evil for yourself.
- They had God's word and let another voice outrank it.
- The damage is total: hiding, shame, exile, blame, pain, cursed ground, and death.
- Genesis 4 to 11 makes it worse, and Genesis 3:15 already promises a rescuer.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. God curses the serpent and the ground but not the man and woman directly. What do you make of that?
2. Romans 8:20 to 21 says creation itself was subjected to futility and will be set free. What in the world around you looks like creation groaning?
3. From Cain to Babel the situation gets worse, not better. Why does the Bible bother telling us that stretch of the story?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- People want to defend God's fairness in the tree and the test. Let the question be asked. The short answer is that love that cannot be refused is not love, and image bearers with no capacity to choose are not image bearers. Do not oversell the answer.

- Someone will treat sin as a list of bad behaviors. The chapter argues something bigger: a rupture in relationship, and a whole creation thrown out of joint. Keep pulling back to that scale.
- The serpent and Satan connection is worth a brief note. Revelation 12:9 identifies the ancient serpent as the devil. Genesis itself does not say so, and it is fine to note that the Bible's own later reading makes the identification.

God's Covenant with Abraham

Part IV, Session 3. Book pages 161 to 172

BIG IDEA

God chose one man in order to bless every nation, and bound Himself to the promise regardless of what Abraham's descendants would do.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

OVER FOOD · Have you ever left somewhere without knowing where you were going? What did that cost?

THEN OPEN WITH · Add Abraham to the wall chart. Follow up on last week's pairs.

READ · Genesis 12:1 to 9, then Genesis 15:1 to 21. Read the covenant ceremony in 15:9 to 17 slowly. It is strange and the strangeness is the point.

SUMMARISE BEFORE YOU ASK · Take two minutes and give the shape of the session out loud, so anyone who has not read it can still think with the group. Then ask whoever did read it what stood out.

ASK THESE THREE ·

1. God tells Abram to leave without telling him the destination. What kind of faith does that require? Where has God asked something like that of you?
2. In Genesis 15 the animals are cut in half and God alone passes between the pieces while Abram sleeps. In that culture both parties walked the path. What is God saying by walking it alone?

3. Genesis 15:6 says Abram believed the LORD and it was counted to him as righteousness. Paul builds his whole argument for justification by faith on that verse. Why does it matter that this comes centuries before the law?

WATCH FOR · The covenant ceremony baffles people. Explain the walk between the pieces plainly.

CLOSE WITH · Where is God asking you to move without showing you the destination? Name it. What is the next step you can actually take this week?

PRAY · Pray for faith to obey without the full picture.

Preparation

Read earlier in the week — not in the room

WHAT THE SESSION SAYS

- A rhythm has emerged: people sin, they face the consequences, God redeems.
- After scattering the nations at Babel, God immediately promises to bless all of them.
- The covenant runs through Genesis 12, 15 and 17. Land is central to it.
- Covenant partners walked between severed animals, invoking that fate on themselves. God walked alone.
- So the covenant holds regardless of what Abraham's descendants do.
- The greatest blessing God offers is Himself: I will be your God and you will be my people.
- Galatians 3 says that in you all the nations will be blessed was the gospel preached in advance.
- God's blessings are to be shared, not hoarded. Abraham believed, and it was counted as righteousness.

IF THE ROOM IS STILL GOING

1. The promise ends with all the families of the earth being blessed. Why does the whole world show up in a promise to one man?
2. Galatians 3:7 to 9 says those of faith are sons of Abraham. What does that make you, in this story?
3. Jesus said Abraham rejoiced to see His day. What do you think Abraham saw?

WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

- The covenant ceremony baffles people. Explain it plainly: cutting a covenant meant walking between severed animals and invoking the same fate on yourself if you break the agreement. God put Abram to sleep and walked alone, taking the full obligation and the full penalty on Himself. That is the gospel in Genesis 15.

- Someone may raise the land promise and modern Israel. This is a live and contested question and it is not tonight's subject. Note that Christians differ, that the New Testament reads the promise as fulfilled in Christ and extended to all who believe, and move on. Do not let it take the room.
- Abraham's failures, the lying about Sarah, Hagar, will come up. Good. The point is that the covenant rests on God's faithfulness, not Abraham's.

Closing Season One

Do not let the season end by simply not meeting again. Take twenty minutes at the end of week twelve, or give it a night of its own.

Walk the wall chart from creation to Abraham, then back further to week one, and let people see how much ground they have covered. Most will have forgotten they started with Luke 14.

Go around the room. Each person names one thing that is different in them since week one. This is the reason the group existed, so do not rush it.

Then be concrete about the break. Say when Season Two starts, how long the gap is, and what you would like people to do in it. A group that scatters with no date usually scatters for good.

Ask the question you have been planting since week two. Is anyone ready to take another person through Parts I to III during the break? They now have the content and the tools, and the nine weeks they have finished are a complete study. If someone says yes, meet with them before Season Two begins and help them plan the first evening.

Finally, pray for the ones who are wavering. Two seasons is a long commitment, and the gap between them is where groups quietly lose people.

Appendix: A leader's checklist

Before each session:

Read the book session twice, once for yourself and once for the group.

Read the anchor passages in context, not just the verses quoted here.

Pick the two threads you will actually pursue. You cannot cover everything and trying to is the most common way these evenings go flat.

Note who has been quiet for two weeks running, and plan a question you will direct to them.

Have last week's commitments written down so you can follow up by name.

During each session:

Start on time and eat properly. The meal is not the preamble to the meeting, it is part of it.

Ask, wait, and do not answer your own question.

Let one silence run longer than is comfortable.

Get every voice in the room at least once.

End with something specific that somebody has to do before you meet again.

After each session:

Write down what was committed and by whom.

Follow up midweek with anyone who seemed off.

Note any question you could not answer and go find an answer.

Appendix: Common problems

Assume some of the room has not read it, and do not make that the story of the evening. Read the summary bullets aloud, or ask someone who did read to give the argument in two minutes, then go straight to the questions. Keep saying that reading is the better way to do this and that turning up unread is still worth doing. The moment coming unprepared feels shameful, people stop coming.

One person dominates. Speak to them privately and enlist them rather than silencing them. Ask them to help you draw out the quiet members. People who talk a lot usually want to be useful.

The group will not go below the surface. This is almost always a leader problem before it is a group problem. Go first, with something real. Depth is granted by example, not requested.

Somebody derails into a hobby horse. Name it warmly, offer to talk after, and return to the text. Do not let a single question consume an evening that eleven other people came for.

Attendance is dropping. Ask why, individually and directly, rather than adjusting the format on a guess. Usually it is logistics, a season, or one relationship that has gone sideways.

Nobody wants to lead. This is the outcome to watch for from session one, which is why the guide keeps asking. If you reach Part V and nobody is close, ask yourself whether you have modeled a leadership that looks possible or one that looks impressive. Aim for possible.